PA 301: Foundations of Public Affairs

The University of Texas at Austin
Lyndon B. Johnson School of Public Affairs
Fall 2026
Class Time: Tuesdays and Thursdays, 3:30-5:00 pm CT
Classroom: LBJ 2.104 (Bass Lecture Hall)

Course Instructor: **Kellen A. Kane, Ph.D., MPA (he/him/his)**,
Assistant Professor of Instruction
Director of Undergraduate Student Success and Enrichment

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What is PA 301?

In this course, students will explore key concepts and debates in the field of public affairs. Four foundational questions guide this course:

1. Why government and public policy?
2. How do public institutions adopt and implement public policy?
3. How should policy be analyzed?
4. Why does policy sometimes fail to deliver what it promises?

Throughout the term, students will review foundational historical texts, influential theoretical writings, and important case studies. By doing so, students will discover a range of domestic and international policy issues. This course meets three lecture hours a week for one semester and is offered on a letter-grade basis only. Foundations of Public Affairs is a required course in the Bachelor of Public Affairs program.

What will I learn in PA 301?

- What are historic rationales for government and public policies?
- What are the organizations, institutions, and policy actors (formal and informal) that motivate and shape public policy?
- How should we evaluate whether a policy is actually working?
- Why do well-intentioned policies so often fall short, and how do they affect groups differently?

What are the required materials?

Textbooks are cost-prohibitive and quickly become outdated. Instead of assigning a course text, I assign a mix of academic articles, book chapters, news reports, podcasts, and engaging video clips to aid my course instruction. All text materials will be made available on our course Canvas page. Links to podcasts and video clips will be provided in the syllabus. If you are unable to access a link in the syllabus, please search for it on Google, then contact a classmate, then contact me.

How will I learn?

Teaching Modality. This course is synchronous and in-person. To accommodate scheduling potential guest speakers or lectures, I reserve the right to designate specific class meetings as virtual. Any potential virtual meeting will be announced well in advance to provide students ample opportunity to secure proper space and equipment to join the class virtually.

Communication. The course Canvas site can be found by navigating to the course page via your Canvas Dashboard. **Please email me through Canvas**. You are responsible for ensuring that the primary email address you have recorded with the university is the one you will check for course communications, as that is the email address Canvas uses.

Asking for Help. Your success in this class is important to me. If any aspect of this course prevents you from learning or excludes you, please let me know as soon as possible. Together, we can develop strategies to meet both your needs and the course expectations. I will have weekly office hours to allow students to seek help on individual assignments, general guidance, or other areas of support. You do not need a class-related reason to meet with me. I am happy to connect with you on any topic!

Required Devices. There will be various days throughout the term when students will be required to have access to a laptop or tablet to complete in-class assignments, such as exams and synchronous activities. These days when electronics will be required will be designated on the Course Calendar.

What are the assignments in this course?

Grade Component	Course Points	Due Date
Policy Current Events	15%, total	Thursday, September 10, 2026 Thursday, October 8, 2026 Thursday, November 19, 2026
In-Class Deliverables and Attendance		
In-Class Deliverable 1: Literature Comparison	5%	Thursday, September 17, 2026
In-Class Deliverable 2: Comparative Communities	5%	In-Class Time: Thursday, November 5, 2026 Due: Tuesday, November 10, 2026
UT Instapolls	5%	Various; throughout entire semester
Policy Brief Project		
Part 1: Annotated Bibliography	10%	Thursday, September 24, 2026
Part 2: Policy Problem Explainer	10%	Thursday, October 29, 2026
Part 3: Informational Policy Brief	15%	Thursday, December 3, 2026
Midterm Exam	15%	Thursday, October 15, 2026
Final Exam	20%	Saturday, December 12, 2026; Scheduled in accordance with the University's Final Exam Schedule

Detailed assignment instructions will be available on the course Canvas page well in advance of the assignment due date. Brief assignment descriptions for all major assignments are included at the end of the syllabus.

How will grades be assigned?

Typically, you will be provided a numerical grade upon receiving feedback. Numerical grades will be translated to letter grades using the rubric below:

Grade	Overall Percentage Range
A	94% - 100%
A-	90% - 93%
B+	87% - 89%
B	84% - 86%
B-	80% - 83%
C+	77% - 79%
C	74% - 76%
C-	70% - 73%
D+	67% - 69%
D	64% - 66%
D-	60% - 63%
F	<60%

Note: Lower grades can be earned. I round up grades, so you need to earn a 93.45 to get an A. I rarely round up more than this.

Course Calendar

Class #	Date	Topic	Readings	Assignment Due
1	Tuesday, August 25, 2026	Course overview; assignment overview; student expectations	• Syllabus	
Module 1: What are the rationales for government, and how do policymakers' incentives shape the scope of what government does?				
2	Thursday, August 27, 2026	Role of government; debates on scope and size of public policies	• Allsop, Jon. 2025. "How Donald Trump is Expanding His Authority While Shrinking the Government". The New Yorker. 5/2/2025.	
3	Tuesday, September 1, 2026	Theories of Power and political perspectives on government	• Bachrach, Peter and Baratz, Morton S. 1962. 'Two Faces of Power', The American Political Science Review, 56 (4), 947-52. • Gill, Timothy. 2018. Why the power elite continues to dominate American politics. Washington Post 12/24/2018.	
	Thursday, September 3, 2026	No class!	• Dr. Kane at the American Political Science Association (APSA) Annual Meeting!	
4	Tuesday, September 8, 2026	Incentives and goals for policymakers	• Fenno, Richard F. Jr. 1978. Home Style: House Members in their Districts. Glenview, Ill.: Scott, Foresman and Company. ***Read Introduction and Chapter 1.***	
5	Thursday, September 10, 2026	Economic rationales for government	• Ostrom, Vincent and Ostrom, Elinor. 1977. "Public Goods and Public Choices". Alternatives for Delivering Public Services. ***Read pages 1-9.*** *Skim the rest of the paper if you would like.* • Ling, Tom. 2020. "What Elinor Ostrom Teaches Us About Avoiding the 'Tragedy of the Commons' in Delivering the Public Interest in the Post COVID-19 World". European Evaluation Society. 6/22/2020.	Policy Current Event #1
6	Tuesday, September 15, 2026	Policy Case Study 1: School Choice	• Cohodes, Sarah and Roy, Susha. 2024. "Thirty Years of Charter Schools: What Does Lottery-Based Research Tell Us?". Blueprint Labs. 8/2024. • Edison, Jaden. 2025. "Private School Vouchers Are Now Law in Texas. Here's How They Will Work." The Texas Tribune. 5/3/2025.	

Class #	Date	Topic	Readings	Assignment Due
7	Thursday, September 17, 2026	Skill building exercise: Consuming policy evidence	• Assigned reading pairs (see Canvas)	In-Class Deliverable 1: Literature Comparison (completed in class)
Module 2: How do government institutions shape the policies that come out of them, and how does that structure affect who gets heard?				
8	Tuesday, September 22, 2026	Models of politics	• Diamond, Larry. 2020. "America's COVID-19 Disaster Is a Setback for Democracy". The Atlantic. 4/16/2020	
9	Thursday, September 24, 2026	U.S. structure: Federalism and Separation of Power	• SoRelle, Mallory E. and Alexis N. Walker. 2017. "Both Democrats and Republicans care about 'states' rights – when it suits them." Washington Post 6/23/17 • Savage, Charles. 2025. "Trump's Maximalist Assertion of Presidential Power Tests the Rule of Law". The New York Times. 4/30/25.	Policy Brief Project #1: Annotated Bibliography
10	Tuesday, September 29, 2026	The bureaucracy and administrative burdens	• Moynihan, Don, 2025. "Why the Supreme Court decision on firing independent agency heads is a big deal". Can We Still Govern? 5/22/2025. • Herd, Pamela and Moynihan, Don. 2025. "Administrative Burdens in the Social Safety Net". Journal of Economic Perspectives. 2025. ***Read pages 129-134**. Skim the rest of the paper if you would like.*	
11	Thursday, October 1, 2026	Legislatures and Courts	• Treisman, Rachel. 2025. "Word of the Week: The swashbuckling origins and evolution of 'filibuster'." NPR. 4/4/2025. • Federalist Society. "How Are State Supreme Court Justices Selected?" 3/14/2019. (5 minutes)	
12	Tuesday, October 6, 2026	Public opinion and the media	• Moynihan, Don (2022). "Anatomy of a fake." Can We Still Govern? • Ho, Shirley, Brossard, Dominique, and Scheufele, Dietram A. (2008). "Effects of Value Predispositions, Mass Media Use, and Knowledge on Public Attitudes Toward Embryonic Stem Cell Research". International Journal of Public Opinion.	
13	Thursday, October 8, 2026	Political representation	• Mansbridge, Jane (1999), 'Should Blacks Represent Blacks and Women Represent Women? A Contingent "Yes"', The Journal of Politics, 61 (3), 628-57.	Policy Current Event #2

Class #	Date	Topic	Readings	Assignment Due
14	Tuesday, October 13, 2026	Policy Case Study 2: Healthcare	• Patashnik, Eric M. 2025. "Introduction: Medicaid at 60". Journal of Health Politics, Policy and Law. 4/2025. • Rolasky, Greg. 2025. "The Paperwork Trap: A Sneaky Way to Cut Medicaid in the 'One Big Beautiful Bill'?". NPR. 6/26/2025. • Totenburg, Nina and Ononye, Anuli. 2025. "Supreme Court Upholds South Carolina's Ban on Medicaid Funds for Planned Parenthood". NPR. 6/26/2025.	
15	Thursday, October 15, 2026	MIDTERM EXAM	• The Midterm Exam will be administered in-person during our class time via Canvas. BRING A LAPTOP OR TABLET TO CLASS.	
Module 3: What does it mean for a policy to 'work', and how do we actually know when it does?				
16	Tuesday, October 20, 2026	The 'people' side of policy: behavioral economics and understanding rationality	• Samson, Alaine. 2014. "An Introduction to Behavioral Economics". Behavioral Economics Guide 2014. • Sunstein, Cass R. 2014. "Nudging: A Very Short Guide". J. Consumer Pol'y. 2014.	
17	Thursday, October 22, 2026	Data and criteria for analyzing policies and programs	• OPRE. 2016. "The Administration for Children & Families Common Framework for Research and Evaluation". 3/2016. • Bardach, Eugene and Patashnik, Eric. 2020. "A Practical Guide for Policy Analysis: The Eightfold Path to More Effective Problem Solving". CQ Press. Chapter 1, pages 31-49. ***Read pages 31-49**. Skim 1-30 if desired. A full eBook is available through UT Library! This book will likely be assigned reading in future PA coursework.*	
18	Tuesday, October 27, 2026	Quantitative and Qualitative Methods 101	• Ford, Tiffany N. and Goger, Annelies. 2021. "The Value of Qualitative Data for Advancing Equity in Policy". The Brookings Institution. 10/14/2021. • The University of Texas at Arlington Libraries. 2024. "Qualitative vs. Quantitative Research"	
19	Thursday, October 29, 2026	Bread and butter of policy: understanding what is (and what isn't) causal inference	• Cunningham, Scott. 2021. "Causal Inference: The Mixtape". Yale University Press. Chapter 1.	Policy Brief Project #2: Policy Problem Explainer
Module 4: Why do well-intentioned policies produce outcomes policymakers did not intend, and what would it actually take to fix that?				

Class #	Date	Topic	Readings	Assignment Due
20	Tuesday, November 3, 2026	What does 'opportunity' mean in the U.S.?: Overview of the Opportunity Atlas	• The Opportunity Insights Team. 2024. "Changing Opportunity: How Changes in Children's Social Environments Have Increased Class Gaps and Reduced Racial Gaps in Economic Mobility". Opportunity Insights at Harvard University. 7/2024.	
	Thursday, November 5, 2026	Skill building exercise: Applying data to policy design	• Comparative Communities assignment to be completed in groups; no formal class meeting -- Dr. Kane at the Association for Public Policy Analysis & Management (APPAM) Fall Research Conference.	
21	Tuesday, November 10, 2026	Unintended policy outcomes	• Chollete, Loran and Harrison, Sharon G. 2021. "Unintended Consequences: Ambiguity Neglect and Policy Ineffectiveness". Eastern Economic Journal (2021) 47:206-226.	In-Class Deliverable 2: Comparative Communities Assignment
22	Thursday, November 12, 2026	*Guest Lecture*: Dr. Kate Weaver, Associate Professor, LBJ School of Public Affairs	• Read about Dr. Weaver's research on **international development** and come prepared with questions: https://lbj.utexas.edu/weaver-catherine	
23	Tuesday, November 17, 2026	Policy Case Study 3: Social Security	• Center on Budget and Policy Priorities. 2024. "Policy Basics: Top Ten Facts about Social Security". 5/31/2024. • Saunders, Tracee, Herd, Pamela, Jilke, Sebastian, Moynihan, Donald, and Safran, Elana. 2025. "Burden Reduction in a Social Safety Net Program Reduces Mortality". OSF Preprints. 4/2/2025. ***Read Abstract and Executive Summary**. Skim rest of the paper if you would like.*	
24	Thursday, November 19, 2026	Improving Public Programs	• Straight Talk on Evidence (2022). "How to Solve U.S. Social Problems when Most Rigorous Program Evaluations Find Disappointing Effects". **Part 1 and Part 2** • Hertel-Fernandez, Alexander (2026). "How Political Science Shaped Federal Policy in the Biden-Harris Administration: Learning from Efforts to Democratize the Administrative State". Perspectives on Politics.	Policy Current Event #3
	Tuesday, November 24, 2026	No class; Fall break		
	Thursday, November 26, 2026	No class; Fall break		

Class #	Date	Topic	Readings	Assignment Due
25	Tuesday, December 1, 2026	*Guest Lecture*: Dr. Anna Gunderson, Associate Professor, LBJ School of Public Affairs	• Read about Dr. Gunderson's research on **criminal justice policy** and come prepared with questions: https://www.annagunderson.com/	
26	Thursday, December 3, 2026	Policy Case Study 4: Digital Government and Course Wrap-Up	• Moynihan et al (2024). Digital governance, algorithmic decision making, and administrative burdens: The Australian Robodebt program • Pahlka, Jennier (2023). "Recoding America: Why Government is Failing in the Digital Age and How We Can Do Better." ***Introduction***	Policy Brief Project #3: Informational Policy Brief
	Saturday, December 12, 2026	FINAL EXAM	• The Final Exam will be administered in-person via Canvas from 1:00 to 3:00pm. BRING A LAPTOP OR TABLET TO OUR EXAM.	

Additional Policies and Items to Note:

Sharing of Course Material. No materials used in this class, including, but not limited to, lecture hand-outs, videos, assessments (quizzes, exams, papers, projects, homework assignments), in-class materials, review sheets, and additional problem sets, may be shared online or with anyone outside of the class without explicit, written permission of the instructor. Unauthorized sharing of materials promotes cheating. The University is aware of the sites used for sharing materials, and any materials found online that are associated with you, or any suspected unauthorized sharing of materials, will be reported to Student Conduct and Academic Integrity in the Office of the Dean of Students. These reports can result in initiation of the student conduct process and include charge(s) for academic misconduct, potentially resulting in sanctions, including a grade impact.

Content warning. Our classroom provides an open space for the critical and orderly exchange of ideas through discussion. Some readings and other content in this course will include topics and comments that some students may find offensive and/or traumatizing. I'll aim to forewarn students about potentially disturbing content, and I ask all students to help to create an atmosphere of mutual respect and sensitivity.

Artificial Intelligence. There are several evolving generative AI technologies at our fingertips. These technologies can be used as tools or as weapons. I hope that students are empowered to learn how to employ them responsibly and ethically as well as to become familiar with their strengths (e.g. ideas generation, summarizing), weaknesses (e.g. garbled and often incoherent writing), biases (e.g. reproduction of stereotypes), and flaws (e.g. hallucinations, incorrect citations). Students are allowed to use advanced automated tools (artificial intelligence or machine learning tools such as ChatGPT or Dall-E 2) on assignments in this course at the prewriting (e.g. identifying references) and editing/revising stages (e.g. grammar tools, thesauri, and diction monitoring) of writing assignments in this course, if and only if, this use is properly documented and credited. **For more information on my expectations on acceptable uses of AI, please consult our Canvas page.**

Academic Integrity Expectations. Students who violate University rules on academic misconduct are subject to the student conduct process. A student found responsible for academic misconduct may be assigned both a status sanction and a grade impact for the course. The grade impact could range from a zero on the assignment in question up to a failing grade in the course. A status sanction can include a written warning, probation, deferred suspension or dismissal from the University. To learn more about academic integrity standards, tips for avoiding a potential academic misconduct violation, and the overall conduct process, please visit the Student Conduct and Academic Integrity website at: http://deanofstudents.utexas.edu/conduct.

Absences. Attendance is expected and crucial for student success in the course. On certain course meetings, attendance will be required to complete in-class assignments and exercises. If you face extreme circumstances that would require you to miss multiple class sessions, talk to me, and we can see what accommodations are available.

Religious Holy Days. By UT Austin policy, you must notify me of your pending absence for a religious holy day as far in advance as possible of the date of observance. If you must miss a class, an examination, a work assignment, or a project in order to observe a religious holy day, you will be given an opportunity to complete the missed work within a reasonable time after the absence. For questions regarding religious accommodations, please contact the Office of the Dean of Students.

Notice of Academic Accommodations from Disability and Access (D&A). The university is committed to creating an accessible and inclusive learning environment for students with disabilities consistent with university policy and federal and state law. Please let me know if you experience any barriers to learning so I can work with you to ensure you have equal opportunity to participate fully in this course. If you are a student with a disability, or think you may have a disability, and need accommodations please contact Disability and Access (D&A). Please refer to D&A's website for contact and more information: http://disability.utexas.edu/. If

you are already registered with D&A , please deliver your accommodation letter to me as early as possible in the semester so we can discuss your approved accommodations and needs in this course.

Late Assignments: Assignments, exams, and quizzes are due at a specified time. I am willing to accommodate only exceptional circumstances if the student made arrangements in advance and the exceptional circumstances are *well documented*. This means that students should get in touch with me days – not hours – before the assignment is due. In fairness to everyone, you should turn in your assignments on time, as additional time is a luxury. Assignments turned in after the deadline *but within three days* of the due date may receive partial credit. Exams are unable to be turned in late.

Re-grading: I will gladly take another look at assignments that students feel are not graded fairly if students approach me about it in my office hours or appointment. I will only do this over 24 hours *after* the grades are returned. The purpose of this waiting period is to give you a chance to really think about the graded item and consider your response. Students must type up a justification for why they believe the score should be different. If I feel the assignment was graded unfairly, I'll change the grade in the student's favor, but I also reserve the right to lower the grade upon reading if, after reevaluation, I think the student received too high a grade. This system is designed to minimize frivolous grade appeals and to ensure that you have carefully examined and reflected on the quality of your work before deciding to initiate a grade appeal. It is also to ensure fairness to all students by ensuring equitable grading standards across students.

Classroom Recording Statement: HOP 2-9970 prohibits students from recording class instruction (audio or video) unless a student obtains the instructor's permission or Disability & Access has approved audio recording as an accommodation. For any questions regarding this, please reach out to me directly.

Additional University Policies and Resources for Students: For additional information on UT Policies and Resources for Students, please see the Canvas supplement to UT syllabi.

Important Safety Information

Carrying of Handguns on Campus

Students in this class should be aware of the following university policies related to Texas' Open Carry Law:

- Students in this class who hold a license to carry are asked to review the university policy regarding campus carry.
- Individuals who hold a license to carry are eligible to carry a concealed handgun on campus, including in most outdoor areas, buildings and spaces that are accessible to the public, and in classrooms.
- It is the responsibility of concealed-carry license holders to carry their handguns on or about their person at all times while on campus. Open carry is NOT permitted, meaning that a license holder may not carry a partially or wholly visible handgun on campus premises or on any university driveway, street, sidewalk or walkway, parking lot, parking garage, or other parking area.

Assignment Descriptions

Policy Current Events. Throughout the course, you will be asked to identify current local, state, national, and international events related to public policy. Current events should occur within a reasonable timeframe of the assignment's due date For each current event submission, you are expected to submit a short summary of the identified current event at the corresponding level of government, identify the policy 'problem,' link the current event to course material, and engage with how the topic may differentially affect various communities. You will complete three current event assignments throughout the semester, weighted equally. Each current event must be at a different level of government (local, state, national, or foreign/international) from previous submissions.

In-Class Deliverables and Attendance: Attendance and participation are built directly into your grade through brief Instapolls woven into lecture, and two more substantive in-class deliverables that require you to be present and working with your peers in real time.

- *Literature Comparison.* There are many ways to frame, analyze, and write about policy issues, and contemporary debates often find people and organizations taking sharply different stances even when working from the same evidence. In this in-class, group-based skill-building workshop, your group will compare a pair of readings on the same policy topic to identify how differing perspectives, audiences, or methodologies shape how the issue is discussed.
- *Comparative Communities Assignment.* In groups, you will compare key outcomes across designated communities based on guided discussion questions. Laptops and tablets will be required for this in-class exercise. After the in-class exercise, you will complete an independent reflection on the data points you discovered about the differences across communities, linking these findings to your own experiences and what they mean for public policy.
- *UT Instapolls*. Throughout the semester, short Instapolls will be incorporated into lecture to spark discussion or review course concepts. Instapolls are graded on completion rather than content, and function primarily as an attendance and engagement check. Your three lowest Instapoll scores will be dropped.

Policy Brief Project. Throughout the term, you will build a policy brief through three components designed to teach you more about a social, political, or economic problem and to explore possible policy solutions.

- *Annotated Bibliography.* Annotated bibliographies provide a summary of a collection of sources and are essential to gaining a deeper understanding of contemporary debates in different policy areas. The primary task of this portion of the policy brief assignment is to provide you the space to engage with scholarly literature in the policy area you have specified as the direction for your term-long assignment.
- *Policy Problem Explainer.* Before you can propose solutions, you need to clearly explain the problem itself. Building on the sources you gathered in your annotated bibliography, you will write a short explainer that lays out the scope of your chosen policy problem, who it affects, and why it matters. This piece sharpens your ability to communicate a policy problem clearly and accessibly, as your Explainer will be written for a general audience.
- *Informational Policy Brief.* Building on the background research you completed in the prior step, now it is your turn to synthesize your findings into a policy brief that reflects on contemporary problems in your selected policy area. For this part of the project, you will take what you learned through your deep dive into the literature about your problem and highlight the policy problem, myths and misconceptions, the politics shaping the problem, and potential solutions.

Exams. This course includes a Midterm Exam and a Final Exam. The questions will go beyond simply restating what was in the lecture slides but instead require applying these concepts to reach a deeper level of thinking.

- *Midterm Exam.* Held partway through the semester, administered in class.
- *Final Exam.* Following the university's final exam schedule, our Final Exam will be held on Saturday, December 12th, from 1:00 to 3:00pm CT. The exam will be cumulative but with a greater focus on the second half of the course material.